

Pharmacy Extern Roles Within a Specialty Pharmacy

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Background

- UI Health Specialty Pharmacy Services (SPS) is a dual accredited specialty pharmacy that was established in 2012.
- SPS manages over 1000 patients with various disease states.
- Pharmacy students undeniably play an integral role in specialty pharmacy operations. Since 2013, pharmacy students have been hired as externs who function in a complementary capacity to specialty pharmacists and technicians.
- To date, over 20 externs have been or are currently employed. Externs are scheduled to accommodate for staffing needs.
- In general, extern's staff on weekends plus early and/or late hours during the week. During Summer and Winter breaks externs work 40 hours per week.

Objective

- We aim to describe how UI Health SPS utilizes externs to benefit pharmacy operations by enhancing patient care and managing essential projects, such that others may learn from these practices and implement them in their settings.

Methodology

- We gathered input from current UI Health SPS pharmacy externs and their operational manager to summarize current practices.

Results

- Since 2013, UI Health SPS has employed at minimum 3 externs per year. Training is ongoing throughout the year and longitudinal, pharmacist-guided projects are transferred to new hires just prior to when the senior extern(s) transition to their APPE rotations.
- One of the main operational roles that externs play is managing the medication delivery service for UI Health SPS. The students perform the packaging of temperature-controlled medications and the hand off with the delivery company.
- In addition to assisting with general pharmacy fulfillment functions such as filling specialty and non-specialty medications, conducting monthly clinical assessment surveys with patients, coordinating medication refills, counseling patients under the supervision of a pharmacist, receiving and transferring prescriptions, and performing medication reconciliations, externs also manage several individual and group projects.
- Each extern-managed project is tailored to match their interests.
- While the COVID-19 pandemic has demonstrated that a significant amount of work can be done remotely, including much of the work done by full-time SPS staff, pharmacy inherently requires on-site contributions. For UI Health SPS, there has been an increased reliance on pharmacy externs for in-person operations since March of 2020.

Number of Externs Employed per Year



List of Projects

- Temperature-controlled shipping validation
- Welcome packet material management
- Prior authorization and reauthorization assistance
- Identification of and outreach to patients for SPS enrollment
- Creating or updating drug cards for new approvals and indications
- Updating Standard Operating Procedures
- Compiling monthly phone data for accreditation reporting

Conclusion

By fully leveraging pharmacy externs, UI Health SPS regularly innovates within the specialty pharmacy umbrella. Pharmacy externs in this setting help with critical tasks related to accreditation, clinical management of patients, and ensure essential components of daily operations are completed. Extern assistance allows for otherwise burdensome work to be prioritized.

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